
‘Hugely exciting’ finds on tiny Scottish island shed light on spread of Christianity

Community-funded archaeological excavations of ‘really important’ sixth-century monastery also rewrite story of Lismore

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Islanders and volunteers have been digging in the early medieval cemetery, where they have discovered the earlier buildings, burial grounds and other finds. Photograph: Robert Hay

To the residents of the Scottish island of Lismore, population 190, history is never very far away. The tiny island near Oban in Argyll has no row of shops or even a pub – if islanders want to meet for a coffee, the only place to do so is in the lively Gaelic heritage centre that records the many centuries of community life on the island.

This quiet place, documentary evidence records, was home to a monastic settlement in the sixth century AD, when missionaries from Ireland were first moving into northern Britain to spread Christianity. But apart from a few fragments of an early carved cross, there was almost nothing to see from this period of history.

A group of local people from the island's historical society were determined to look a bit harder, however. After scraping together funding from grants, donations and legacies of locals and a crowdfunding campaign, they commissioned a professional archaeologist, Dr Clare Ellis of Argyll Archaeology, to lead a group of islanders and other volunteers in an excavation on the site of a much later medieval cathedral.

Their “hugely exciting” findings have not only rewritten the story of the island but cast new light on the spread of Christianity in the period, according to archaeologists. What the islanders discovered were extensive burial grounds, decorated stonework and early buildings – all the features belonging to a major sixth-century monastery, comparable to the much better known site of Iona a little to the south-west.

In addition, the excavations uncovered rare evidence of slightly later high-status craftworking, including huge numbers of crucibles which had been used to cast gold and silver. The finds have shown that rather than being a small island church in an overlooked backwater, the monastery of Lios Mór, founded by Saint Mo Luóc or Moluag, was a high-ranking site of international importance, experts say.

To Robert Hay, a retired plant scientist who moved to the island in 2001 and who coordinated the fundraising and volunteer efforts, the experience was thrilling. “We were [excavating] in this really unfavourable, boggy area. To be digging out the best small crucibles ever found in Scotland – it's extraordinary,” he said.



A crucible freshly out of the soil. Photograph: Robert Hay

“The most exciting moment for me was when they were doing the post-excavation analysis and they found that they had been melting gold, copper, silver, and they were making jewellery on our little island in the seventh century.”

While plenty of islanders have an idle interest in its history, a “dynamic minority” of mostly older people had mustered the volunteers and funds to carry out the digs, said Hay. Raising the low five-figure sum needed to pay for it all had been “just a business of getting down to it and organising and so on”, he said. “It was actually a lot easier than what my previous job used to be.”

Gordon Noble, a professor of archaeology at the University of Aberdeen, said the finds were highly significant. “We know about sites like Iona having these very famous monastic sites from this early medieval world. But apart from the association with Moluag and a piece of sculpture from this site, we knew practically nothing really about Lismore. So it was hugely exciting to see the results emerging through the local group’s work with Clare [Ellis] ... This was clearly a really important early Christian establishment.”

While professional archaeologists often worked with local people, Noble said, “it’s not always the community themselves coming up with the ideas. Here, it was very much a bottom-up approach of the heritage society coming up with a plan, working with professionals – and lo and behold, what a great series of discoveries they’ve made at the site.”

Hay said he hoped the finds would go some way to restoring the reputation of Moluag, who has long been overshadowed by the more celebrated Saint Columba, the founder of Iona and the subject of an influential ninth-century biography. “Unfortunately, Moluag never had a hagiographer, so his contribution to the evangelisation of Scotland has been very much underestimated,” he said. “So finding his monastic site and [the evidence of metalworking] – it’s all about recalibrating the situation. I think Moluag had a very big impact on the evangelising of Scotland, but unfortunately, he didn’t get his PR right.”

The results of the community excavations will be published in the forthcoming edition of *Antiquity*.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
shed light on	短语	揭示、使……得以看清	finds shed light on the spread of Christianity 考古发现让基督教传播的情况得以看清； 文中另有变体 cast new light on
excavation	n.	发掘、挖掘	community-funded archaeological excavations 社区出资的考古发掘；动词 excavate，文中引语亦见 “We were [excavating]...”

词	词性	中文	备注
monastic	adj.	修道院的、修士的	a monastic settlement 修道院聚落；名词 monastery 修道院（文 中的 Lios Mór 即一 例）
scrape together	短语	（费力一点点）凑齐	scraping together funding from grants, donations and legacies 从拨款、捐款、遗赠 中凑钱；本义“刮、 擦”
commission	v.	出资聘请、委托	commissioned a professional archaeologist 出资聘请 职业考古学家；名词 另义“佣金”
crucible	n.	坩埚	huge numbers of crucibles used to cast gold and silver 用于熔 铸金银的大量坩埚
cast	v.	铸造；投射	had been used to cast gold and silver 用来铸 金银；短语 cast light on 揭示、使清楚
backwater	n.	闭塞落后之地	a small island church in an overlooked backwater 被忽视的闭 塞小地方的一座小教 堂；本义“回水、死 水”
overlook	v.	忽视、忽略	an overlooked backwater 被忽视的角 落；另义“俯瞰”
muster	v.	集结、组织起	had mustered the volunteers and funds 把 志愿者和资金组织起 来；另义 muster (up) courage 鼓起勇气
low five-figure sum	短语	五位数的低端金额	Raising the low five- figure sum needed to pay for it all 凑出所需 的这笔低五位数资

词	词性	中文	备注
			金； five-figure = 一万至十万， low 指区间低端
bottom-up	adj.	自下而上的	a bottom-up approach of the heritage society coming up with a plan 由本地遗产协会提出方案的自下而上做法； 反义 top-down
lo and behold	短语	你瞧、想不到（表惊喜）	and lo and behold, what a great series of discoveries 你瞧，多漂亮的一连串发现； 古语残留， 引语中多见
overshadow	v.	使黯然失色、 盖过	long been overshadowed by the more celebrated Saint Columba 长期被更有名的圣科伦巴盖过
hagiographer	n.	圣徒传记作者	Moluag never had a hagiographer 莫卢阿格无人为他立传； hagiography 圣徒传， 亦讽“歌功颂德之作”
evangelisation	n.	福音传播、 （使）皈依基督教	his contribution to the evangelisation of Scotland 对苏格兰福音化的贡献； 动词 evangelise
recalibrate	v.	重新校准、 重新调整（评价）	it's all about recalibrating the situation 就是要重新校准这件事的定位； calibrate 校准（仪器）
forthcoming	adj.	即将出版的、 即将到来的	the forthcoming edition of Antiquity 即将出刊的那一期《古物》学报； 学术语境高频
idle	adj.	闲暇的、 随意的	an idle interest in its history 对历史的闲散兴趣； 另义“闲置的”